from even the Prime Minister's Office to re-examine or stop the awarding of Ph.D. Similarly, concerns were raised in 2017 when IIM-A appointed suspended IPS officer Rajnish Rai as an assistant professor. The institute had refused to toe the government line. Later in 2022, the institute board did not comply with the government's desire to let Kumar Mangalam Birla continue as chairman for another year till the amendments to the autonomy bill were brought in. The dismissal of IIM Calcutta director Anju Seth by its board and the chairman after she alleged financial irregularities and violation of government guidelines opened another pandora's box on how the IIMs use their autonomy.

Sources claim the government regretted the 2017 Act within months of its clearance. Proponents of the new bill suggest that the autonomy did not yield the desired outcomes. Former IIM-A director Dr Bakul Dholakia views the amendments as a potential damage-control measure rather than damaging. "IIM-A's rank was 11 on FT global rankings for one-year PGPX in 2011. In 2023, the rank is 51! Not a single IIM figures in the top 50 global B-schools. The Indian School of Business, Hyderabad, ranks 31/32," he says.

The worry over rankings finds resonance with the larger IIM alumni communities. Reflecting on their sentiments, Parikh says there is indeed fear of government intervention impacting IIMs' functioning, but the need to improve their rankings is imperative now.



"EVEN IF THE GOVT NOMINEES ARE IN THE MINORITY, NO IIM BOARD WOULD LIKE TO PASS ANY MAJOR DECISION WITHOUT THEIR CONSENT"

–NAYAN PARIKH
IIM-A alumnus and former member, IIM-A board

Dholakia says the IIMs are public institutions and need to be accountable. "There are concerns about the biases of the Visitor, but what about the bias of the board or chairman? The director had become the chairman's nominee. Board members and the chairman are essentially representatives of the industry and corporates. At least the Visitor's office is publicly accountable," adds the veteran who was IIM-A director between 2002 and 2007. He emphasises that the absence of checks and balances in the current autonomous system led to the controversy over the modification of the IIM-A logo and the renovation of the institute's old heritage campus. "The alumni and faculty had serious concerns about the logo and heritage centre. The board did not heed these concerns," he explains.

Dholakia also allays fears about interference. "Nothing in the amendments talks about clamping down on the IIMs' academic autonomy. In fact, the IIMs are in serious breach of statutory compliance. The 2017 Act says 'an independent review by an external agency must be conducted every three years'," he says. "Except for IIM Bangalore, none of the 19 IIMs have done it. Earlier, IIM reports were placed before Parliament. Some of the rich IIMs have endowment funds in the region of Rs 1,000 crore. But, where is the accountability?" The director's office at IIM-A refused to comment.

How can one resolve this? The IIMs' path forward lies in finding a delicate equilibrium between maintaining their hard-earned autonomy and ensuring accountability as they strive to improve their rankings. ■

ASSAM

Sleaze, Suicide and a Job Scam

By Kaushik Deka

The suicide of a woman BJP leader in Assam has snowballed into a major "cash-for-jobs scam", which resulted in the arrest of five individuals, all linked to the saffron party. The controversy has sent shockwaves across the state as the Himanta Biswa Sarma-led BJP government, for the past two years, has been receiving public applause for introducing transparency in the recruitment process of government jobs. Job aspirants, particularly from the rural areas and economically backward sections, have often publicly acknowledged that they got government jobs through a merit-based recruitment test and did not have to pay any bribe.

On August 11, Indrani Tahbildar, general secretary of the Kisan Morcha of the Assam BJP, died by suicide at her Guwahati home after her alleged intimate photos with Anurag Chaliha, a Kisan Morcha member from her home district Golaghat, had gone viral on social media. Based on a complaint